

An **essay** is, generally, a piece of writing that gives the author's own [argument](#), but the definition is vague, overlapping with those of a [letter](#), a [paper](#), an [article](#), a [pamphlet](#), and a [short story](#). Essays have been sub-classified as formal and informal: formal essays are characterized by "serious purpose, dignity, logical organization, length," whereas the informal essay is characterized by "the personal element (self-revelation, individual tastes and experiences, confidential manner), humor, graceful style, rambling structure, unconventionality or novelty of theme," etc.^[1]

Essays are commonly used as [literary criticism](#), political [manifestos](#), learned [arguments](#), observations of daily life, recollections, and reflections of the author. Almost all modern essays are written in [prose](#), but works in [verse](#) have been dubbed essays (e.g., [Alexander Pope's *An Essay on Criticism*](#) and [An Essay on Man](#)). While brevity usually defines an essay, voluminous works like [John Locke's *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*](#) and [Thomas Malthus's *An Essay on the Principle of Population*](#) are counterexamples.

In some countries (e.g., the United States and Canada), essays have become a major part of formal [education](#).^[2] Secondary students are taught structured essay formats to improve their writing skills; [admission essays](#) are often used by [universities](#) in selecting applicants, and in the humanities and social sciences essays are often used as a way of assessing the performance of students during final exams.

The concept of an "essay" has been extended to other media beyond writing. A [film essay](#) is a movie that often incorporates documentary filmmaking styles and focuses more on the evolution of a theme or idea. A [photographic essay](#) covers a topic with a linked series of [photographs](#) that may have accompanying text or [captions](#).